of the bhaunra. In another one he likened the beloved's wink to the motion of the lotus flower when the bhaunra alights on it.

To bid a fitting farewell to Tansen, whose extraordinary music had accompanied him these many decades, Akbar ordered that his funeral procession be resplendent with the best musicians and dancers of the city, and that he be sent off joyously, in melody, like a groom to his beloved, in the manner of the Sufis. Two days later, almost as if to shake off his sadness, Akbar decided to journey to Kashmir.

After its relatively straightforward annexation from the Chak dynasty in 1586, Akbar had not yet visited Kashmir. Now, suddenly, he became impatient to leave and Abu'l Fazl agreed that 'he does not fix his heart to one place…' His courtiers were unhappy about the journey, loath to see the Padshah journey so far from the heartland of the empire but Akbar would not listen to them. '[O]ur going there is…the fulfilling of (Humayun's) dream', he said. Babur's cousin, Mirza Dughlat, had, in fact, ruled the Kashmir valley on behalf of Humayun from 1541 to 1551 so it is not impossible that Humayun would have talked to his son of a desire to journey there one day.

Akbar ordered Qasim Khan, the engineer of the Agra–Lahore road, and of Agra Fort, to make the road to Kashmir passable. Qasim Khan used 3,000 stonecutters, 2,000 diggers, mountain-miners, and 'splitters of rocks' to transform what was a pedestrian-only track into a highway which could be used by the Mughal army with its lumbering elephants, cavalry, and guns. This road had earlier been used to transport salt from the Punjab to Kashmir, and was called the Namak Road. Under the Mughals it would become the most important road connecting the landlocked valley of Kashmir to Hindustan and would come to be known as the Mughal Imperial Road.

Leaving Lahore in the care of Raja Bhagwant Das, Raja Todar Mal, and Qulij Khan, Akbar set off for Kashmir in the month of May. When he reached Bhimbhar, he suddenly decided to proceed alone with only a small retinue of courtiers including Prince Salim and Abu'l Fazl. Prince Murad was left in charge of the harem and an officer was stationed at Bhimbhar Pass to prevent any other courtiers or attendants from following the Padshah. Akbar made rapid progress on horseback till he crossed Rajauri and reached the tents of Qasim Khan who was directing the operations for the clearing of the roads. Salim was sent back to Bhimbhar with orders to